

CORE FORMULA

COIN = Context -> Observation -> Impact -> Next step. -> Context: "In yesterday's client handoff..." -> Observation: "...the risk note was missing from the summary..." -> Impact: "...so the next person had to reconstruct the issue under time pressure..." -> Next step: "...next time, please add the risk note before sending the handoff." -> Compact: "In [moment], I noticed [observable behaviour]. The impact was [specific effect]. Next time, could we [workable next step]?"

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

In [context], I noticed [behaviour]. The impact was [effect]. Next time, can we [specific next step]?

BEST FOR

- Manager feedback anchored to one recent example
- Peer-to-peer friction without formal authority
- Collaboration breakdowns and missed handoffs
- Quality issues with a clear, specific instance
- Meetings where one behaviour is creating avoidable cost
- Relationship repair after a specific incident
- When the next step can be made concrete

PHRASE BANK

Soft entries · Openers & permission

- "Can I share one specific behaviour-impact note?"
- "Can I give you one quick piece of feedback from today?"
- "Have you got a minute for one small observation?"
- "Mind if I flag one thing from the handoff?"
- "One quick note from the meeting, if that's okay?"
- "Can I name one thing I noticed earlier?"

Fill-in scaffolds · Core formula templates

- "In [context], I noticed [behaviour]. The impact was [effect]. Next time, can we [next step]?"
- "In [moment], I noticed [observable behaviour]. The impact was [specific effect]. Could we [workable next step]?"
- "The behaviour I noticed was [X], and the effect was [Y]."
- "Next time, could we [specific next step]?"
- "Can we agree [next step] for next time?"
- "That's how I saw the impact. What am I missing?"
- "Does that next step work for you?"

Work & meetings · Manager and peer feedback

- "In this morning's review, I noticed we moved past the risk question before Alex had finished. The impact was that we lost the thread and had to reopen it later. Next time, can we let the owner finish before moving on?"
- "In today's planning meeting, the task owner changed before the risk was discussed. The impact was that two people left with different assumptions. Next time, can we confirm the risk before assigning the owner?"
- "In the planning chat, I noticed my estimate was changed before I'd explained the constraint. The impact was that the plan looked cleaner than it was. Next time, can we check the constraint before changing the number?"
- "In the last client update, the risk caveat was missing. The impact was that support had to answer the same question repeatedly. Next time, please include the caveat before the update goes out."
- "In the planning thread, the owner changed before the dependency was confirmed. The impact was rework. Next time, can

we confirm dependencies before assigning the owner?"

- "In the retro, we skipped the action review. The impact was that the same issue came back this sprint. Next time, can we hold five minutes for actions?"
- "Can I give one specific note from today's meeting?"
- "In the review, the numbers changed after sign-off. The impact was that I briefed the wrong figure. Next time, can we lock the version before it goes out?"

Upward & firm · Feedback under stakes

- "In yesterday's stand-up, the deadline changed while the blockers were still open. The impact is that I'm not sure which priority to protect. Could we confirm the priority before I re-plan?"
- "In yesterday's prioritisation meeting, the deadline changed before blockers were reviewed. The impact is that I'm not sure what to drop. Could we confirm the trade-off before I re-plan?"
- "One COIN note: in the handoff the blocker was absent; it delayed triage; next time, flag blockers in the first line."
- "This one isn't optional: the caveat needs to be in before the release goes live."
- "In the last two handoffs, the status field was blank. That meant the next person had to chase context. From tomorrow, please fill the status line before you close the task."
- "I need to be straight about the effect here, then I'd like to hear your side."

Warm & relationship repair · Calm, personal delivery

- "I value how we work together, so I want to flag one small thing."
- "This is a small thing, and I'm only raising it because it's easy to fix."
- "When we talked last night, I interrupted twice while you were explaining. The impact was that you had to restart your point. Next time, I'll pause and ask before responding."
- "I might be missing context here, so tell me if I've read it wrong."
- "None of this is about you as a person — it's one moment I wanted to name."
- "I'd rather say this directly than let it sit, because I think you'd want to know."

Digital & written · Text and message-length

- "Context: the last release note. Observation: the migration caveat was missing. Impact: support fielded the same question repeatedly. Next step: add caveats before release notes go live."
- "Quick note on the handoff: status field was blank, so the next person had to chase context. Could we fill it before closing next time?"
- "One thing from the doc: the owner wasn't set, so two of us started the same task. Can we assign it before sharing?"
- "Small flag: the deadline moved but the blockers didn't get updated. Can we sync those so the plan matches?"
- "Noticed the caveat dropped off this version — support got the same question three times. Add it back before the next send?"
- "Behaviour: numbers changed after sign-off. Impact: the wrong figure went out. Next step: lock the version first?"

Softening & inviting correction · Lower the temperature

- "I made that sound broader than I meant. I'm talking about one moment, not your character."
- "I don't want to push this if now is the wrong moment — we can pause and come back to it."
- "You may have context I don't. I'd like to hear that before we settle the next step."
- "Let me narrow that to the behaviour rather than a judgement about you."
- "If the next step doesn't work, tell me and we'll find one that does."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "You are unreliable and your updates are always messy." Labels character, exaggerates and offers no repair path.

Better: "The last update was missing the status and owner, so I had to ask three follow-up questions." Observable and impact-based, but still needs a next step.

Best: "In yesterday's handoff, the status and owner fields were blank. The impact was that triage took an extra ten minutes and the next owner was unclear. Next time, can you fill both fields before closing the handoff?"

2. Weak: "You were dismissive in there." An interpretation dressed as a fact — easy to deny.

Better: "You spoke over the last two sentences before I finished the risk point." A clean observation, but no consequence or ask.

Best: "In the risk discussion, I got spoken over before I finished, so the risk didn't get logged. Next time, can we let each point land before responding?"

3. Weak: "You made everyone miserable on Friday." Turns impact into guilt and mind-reads the room.

Better: "The decision had to be reopened after the meeting." States a real effect, but leaves it hanging.

Best: "In Friday's call, the decision was reopened after we'd closed it. The impact was an extra hour for six people. Next time, can we confirm everyone's a yes before we move on?"

DECISION TREE

If The issue isn't one specific behaviour

Don't use COIN yet — clarify what actually happened first.

"Can you walk me through what happened there?"

If They're visibly distressed

Lead with emotion first (validation or NURSE) before any feedback.

"This looks like a hard moment. Do you want to talk about that first?"

If They dispute your observation

Pause the note and ask for their version before continuing.

"What did you see from where you were sitting?"

If The next step is negotiable

Invite a workable alternative rather than dictating.

"Would that work, or is there a better way to handle it?"

If The next step is non-negotiable

State it calmly and don't pretend it's a shared choice.

"This part isn't up for discussion, but I'll explain why."

If They understand and agree the next behaviour

Summarise, thank them, and stop — don't keep restating it.

"Great — so we're agreed on that for next time. Thanks."

SCENARIOS

Manager feedback on a specific incident

Anchor to one recent example and end with a concrete operational next step. — "In the last client update, the risk caveat was missing. The impact was that support answered the same question repeatedly. Next time, please include the caveat before it goes out."

Peer collaboration without authority

Keep it a joint request, not an order — you're asking, not instructing. — "In the planning thread, the owner changed before the dependency was confirmed. The impact was rework. Next time, can we confirm dependencies before assigning the owner?"

Upward feedback to someone senior

Focus on the practical cost to the work, not the person's judgement. — "In yesterday's meeting, the deadline changed before blockers were reviewed. The impact is that I'm not sure what to drop. Could we confirm the trade-off before I re-plan?"

Relationship repair

Name your own behaviour first, then propose the shared fix. — "When we talked last night, I interrupted twice while you were explaining. The impact was that you had to restart. Next time, I'll pause and ask before responding."

Digital or written feedback

Use short labelled lines only when clarity matters more than warmth. — "Context: last release note. Observation: caveat missing. Impact: repeated support questions. Next step: add caveats before release."

Group retrospective

Run COIN on the process, not a person, unless a direct person-to-person channel is appropriate. — "In the retro, we skipped the action review, and the same issue returned. Next time, can we hold five minutes for actions?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- They are flooded, ashamed, panicking or grieving
- They are unsafe, intoxicated or unable to process feedback
- The issue needs formal investigation, HR, legal or disciplinary process

- Safeguarding or immediate safety action is required
- Your real aim is punishment, superiority or venting
- You are stacking old grievances rather than naming one moment
- You cannot yet state the behaviour as a clean observation

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot clean observations

Take five vague judgements you've thought this week ("he's dismissive", "she's careless") and rewrite each as one observable behaviour a camera could have caught.

Day 2 — Write the four parts

Pick one real but low-stakes behaviour from the past week. Write a single sentence each for Context, Observation, Impact and Next step.

Day 3 — Cut and de-motive

Take yesterday's draft. Circle every word that implies motive or character, swap it for observable behaviour, then cut the whole message by 30 percent.

Day 4 — Add the invitation

Append one calibration line — "What am I missing?" or "Does that next step work?" — and read the note aloud twice: once too formal, once as plain speech.

Day 5 — Rehearse recovery

Practise three repair lines aloud so they're ready if the feedback lands as blame: narrow it to the behaviour, disclaim intent, and invite the context you might be missing.

Day 6 — Choose the right tool

For five situations (someone distressed, a twice-missed field, unsure if advice is welcome, expressing a need without blame, plain behaviour feedback), decide whether COIN, NURSE, Ask-tell-ask, NVC or validation fits, and why.

Day 7 — Use it live

In one real, low-stakes moment, deliver a full COIN note, then score it: specific context, clean observation, concrete impact, workable next step, autonomy preserved.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I choose one specific context rather than a pile of grievances?
- Would a fair person recognise my observation without having to agree with my interpretation?
- Did I avoid mind-reading, exaggeration and character labels?
- Did I name the impact without turning it into guilt?
- Is the next step clear enough to act on, with room to correct it?
- Did I stop once the next behaviour was clear, and did this leave dignity intact?